
Columns

A Difficult Debut at *Negotiation Journal*

*Deborah M. Kolb, Michael Wheeler
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This issue marks a very difficult debut for us as editors of *Negotiation Journal*, a publication that Jeffrey Z. Rubin literally defined from its first issue in 1985 through all of the 1995 volume year. We greatly miss our dear friend and colleague, who died in a hiking accident last June in Maine at the age of 54.

Jeff worked diligently to insure that this journal would be read by, and be useful to, an eclectic readership of negotiation scholars and practitioners. He was a superb "boundary spanner" in this highly diverse field, and succeeded brilliantly in encouraging, editing, and publishing thought-provoking articles about the processes of negotiation and negotiation theory. He strongly believed that a sound theoretical framework informs practice,

and that theory evolves from the experience of those who practice.

Jeff — who loved using theatrical metaphors — is surely one "hard act to follow." His contributions to the readers and essayists of *Negotiation Journal* were unique. Though we can never be the "one, singular sensation" that our brilliant friend was, we shall look to his outstanding accomplishment as a guide and model in preparing each issue of *Negotiation Journal*. In the coming months, astute readers may notice a few editorial changes, but these will be of the evolutionary, not revolutionary, variety.

Starting with this issue (in keeping with an innovation planned by Jeff Rubin), most articles in *Negotiation Journal* are now preceded by an abstract. It is our hope that these

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very brief summations will assist scholars and librarians in their work, as well as provide a "taste" of a particular article to the negotiation practitioner. Abstracts in no way substitute for reading an article, but they should serve as guides to the contents of the work and thus assist the reader in knowing whether or not that work is pertinent.

Along these same lines, *Negotiation Journal* — in addition to articles reporting on research, such as that written by Debra Shapiro and Jörn Rognes in this issue — will regularly feature condensed "translations" of negotiation research that most practitioners (to say nothing about many scholars) may never have the opportunity to read.

Scholarly journals specializing in management studies, psychology, the law, sociology, economics, communications, and many other fields often feature articles that report on research of interest to the greater negotiation community. However, because of the context of a particular journal, that research is frequently overlooked. For example, a family mediator may not regularly read a journal like *Administrative Science Quarterly*, but that publication could well feature a research report on styles of negotiation that has relevance to the mediator's practice. By presenting a précis of the work in *Negotiation Journal*, we hope to improve the links between the practitioner and the academic community. A talented group of graduate students at universities affiliated with the Program on Negotiation at Harvard Law School is already working on this project, which will begin

with the April 1996 issue. As always, reader suggestions are welcome.

Regular Features

At this point in time, we anticipate no changes in the major types of articles we publish — columns, "in theory" and "in practice" essays, case studies, research reports, teaching ideas, integrative book reviews, and general news. These categories have worked well in the past, and there does not seem to be any reason to change them.

In general, columns are short, informal pieces that some contributors regard as "off-the-top-of-my-head" comments about a particular aspect of negotiation practice or theory. They frequently serve as a spur to readers to consider some of the most vexing questions in the field. In this issue, for example, Sheila Heen's observations about the very different approaches taken by her male and female negotiation students point to issues that are crucial to our understanding of negotiation process, and of obvious impact on the work of both scholars and professional negotiators.

Two articles in this issue's "In Practice" section offer descriptions of new techniques that are helping to expand negotiation theory into new areas. Lawrence Susskind, Abram Chayes, and Janet Martinez describe "parallel informal negotiation," a strategy aimed at developing collaborative approaches to international negotiation. A particularly interesting aspect of their work is that it is taking place among international negotiators from contexts (the environment and trade) which for-

merly had little or nothing to do with one another.

In the article that follows, Randa Slim and Harold H. Saunders describe a five-stage unofficial "dialogue" process and "civil society" strategy that are being used in Tajikistan, the former Soviet republic where thousands have died in a bloody, bitter conflict over the last several years. Sadly, the "divided society" of Tajikistan is hardly unique in this war-torn world; thus, the initiatives described by Slim and Saunders have implications for negotiators in many other locales.

The "in theory" section of this issue includes two very different articles, both of which are linked, however, by their overarching focus on the enhancement of our understanding of the theoretical framework that underlies negotiation. Michael Watkins and Susan Rosegrant, using a crisply-written description of how the administration of former U.S. President George Bush forged a worldwide alliance to fight Iraq's Saddam Hussein, tell us much about how coalitions can be formed and the role of power in such negotiations. This analysis draws from research based in a number of disciplines, and should likewise prove instructive for negotiators in many different arenas.

"Neutrality" is almost a sacred concept for some mediators. However, as pointed out by Kevin Gibson, Leigh Thompson, and Max Bazerman in the next article, its appeal is matched only by its difficult nature. Instead of the goal of neutrality, this trio of authors proposes "symmetric prescriptive

advice," an idea that has implications in negotiations ranging from the business world to divorce mediation, from labor-management conflict to international relations.

Research results that may be surprising to some readers are reported in the following section by Debra L. Shapiro and Jörn Rognes. They studied the techniques used by American and Norwegian negotiators, and found that — when push comes to shove — sometimes the end result of the negotiation is more integrative than might be expected. As usual, the issue concludes with our "news and notes" section, including capsule descriptions of recently published books of interest to the negotiation audience.

Future Topics

Though not included in this issue, several integrative book review-essays are planned for the future. Among the topics will be: global environmental negotiations, negotiations in the workplace of today (and tomorrow), and the impact of culture and gender on negotiation processes.

Works in preparation for other sections of the *Journal* include: several articles exploring the "new" industrial relations; a critique of the alternative dispute resolution movement; the reflections of a college professor who has been teaching negotiation for the past quarter century; an analysis of what we have learned from divorce and family mediation research; an exploration of the linkages between internal and external negotiations; a new look at

the differences between interests and positions in negotiation; and an outline of the roles third parties can play in the prevention of international conflict.

As the field continues to grow, we welcome the opportunity of publishing well-written, thought-provoking articles by both scholars and practitioners that help all of us to learn more about the way individuals,

organizations, and nations negotiate. Potential contributors¹ are advised to read the *Journal's* Editorial Policy — originally written by Jeff Rubin — to learn more about the kinds of articles we shall be publishing.

Jeff truly is a "hard act to follow." Fortunately, however, he also provided us with friendship and guidance over the years, and a model whose standards we aspire to meet.

NOTE

1. *Negotiation Journal* annually considers approximately 200 article submissions, and publishes between 35 and 40 of that number. Our rejection rate in recent years has ranged from 80 to 83 percent of all submissions received.

Approximately 65 percent of all submissions are sent out for formal review by peers in both the academic world and in the dispute resolution profession.

Members of the Editorial Policy Committee and International Advisory Board of *Negotiation Journal* are particularly generous with their time and talent in providing reviews of material submitted for possible publication. In addition, many past contributors and others have served as reviewers. We are most appreciative of the constructive criticism that our reviewers provide, and welcome the opportunity to thank them publicly for their efforts. This publication would not be possible without them.